CINEMA

THE METHOD MATTERS

An indie favourite, actor Shahana Goswami is back with her first theatrical release since 2018–Nandita Das's *Zwigato*

Shahana Goswami has a preternatural ability to make her presence felt regardless of the duration of her part. The effortless ease of her performance was evident in acclaimed indies *Tu Hai Mera Sunday* (2016) and *Gali Guleiyan* (2017), and it's what she does in Nandita Das's upcoming feature, *Zwigato*, playing supportive wife Pratima to Kapil Sharma's Manas, a struggling food delivery provider in Bhubaneswar. "Pratima's story is secondary to the bigger picture, but Goswami makes her a woman of patience and understanding," said a review in *Screen Daily* after the film's world premiere in Busan last year. The drama releases in Indian theatres on March 17.

It makes one wonder why Goswami isn't a recurring fixture–*Zwigato* is her first theatrical release since 2018. She understands the grouse, but with 18 years of industry experience, she feels her trajectory is one with fewer regrets and more enriching parts. She enjoys the reputation of being an indie film darling who delivers. "People will always put you in a slot," she says. "When you shift gears, you have to wait it out for something you actually want to do." Goswami started out doing supporting parts in relatively commercial films like *Honeymoon Travels Pvt. Ltd.* (2007) and *Rock On!!* (2008). Then came big-budget fare: *Break Ke Baad* (2010), *Ra.One* (2011) and *Heroine* (2012). "I gained different things from those films, but not creative satisfaction," she says. That has changed now with the rise of OTT platforms. Goswami stood out for her role as a woman excelling at work but struggling to keep her marriage together in Alankrita Shrivastava's feminist drama *Bombay Begums* (2021, Netflix). "The volume of work increases and it allows different storytelling and narrative styles," she says. "But I want to do something that surprises me and the audience." Her co-actor, popular comedian and TV show host Kapil Sharma, she adds, does exactly that in *Zwigato*.

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The film marks her second collaboration with Das after *Firaaq* (2008) and she is all praise for the actor-filmmaker's 'tenacity' and for etching a part like Pratima. Says Goswami, "She has a great sense of clarity and is thorough with the storytelling and the subtleties, layers and nuances." Goswami believes *Zwigato* is Das's best work to date. For Goswami, *Zwigato* is the beginning of a promising year. There's a small but impactful part opposite Manoj Bajpayee in *Despatch* and another in the Anu Menon-directed Amazon Prime Video film, *Neeyat*, which also stars Vidya Balan. She has also shot for a short, part of an anthology, directed by National Award-winning Assamese filmmaker Rima Das (*Village Rockstars*, 2017). They may not be 'big' projects, but for Goswami, what matters is the big heart at the core of the collaborative process. ■

Suhani Singh





CINEMA SPECULATION
By Quentin Tarantino
W&N/ Hachette India
₹899; 392 pages

BOOKS

Flick Fanboy

Cult filmmaker **Quentin Tarantino** is a true-blue fan of the movies

Reading Quentin Tarantino's movie memoir *Cinema Speculation* is like falling in love. Tarantino is the great film director of our time who entered adolescence in the 1970s; in this book, he recounts becoming an aficionado of 'revengeamatics' and blaxploitation films while barely a tween—he accompanied his mother on her dates to the B-film double-bill of the day. After she and his stepfather split, she had a series of black boyfriends, which moulded his movie experience; watching former US football star Jim Brown's *Black Gunn* (1972) in a theatre filled with black men, Tarantino had an epiphany: "To one degree or another, I've spent my entire life since attending movies and making them, trying to recreate the experience of watching a brand-new Jim Brown film, on a Saturday night, in a black cinema in 1972."

And if Tarantino's *Once Upon a Time in... Hollywood* (2019) was an homage to Steve McQueen and the end of both the old Hollywood and the 1960s, *Cinema Speculation* is an homage to the 1970s and the New Hollywood, where the staple of Westerns was replaced by violent crime films, both genres subtly giving the audience an unvarnished look at race relations in the United States.

The book giddily bursts with an encyclopaedia of movies, and 13 of its chapters are headlined after defining movies for Tarantino: *Bullitt* (1968), *Dirty Harry* (1971), *Deliverance* (1972), *The Getaway* (1972), *The Outfit* (1973), *Sisters* (1972), *Daisy Miller* (1974), *Taxi Driver* (1976), *Rolling Thunder* (1977), *Paradise Alley* (1978), *Escape from Alcatraz* (1979), *Hardcore* (1979) and *The Funhouse* (1981). Obviously, Tarantino, lacking a stable father-figure, likes the tough guys. One chapter pays tribute to the second-string critics that kept B-movies alive; the book's coda is to a black ex-boyfriend of his mom's friend, a sometime tenant who indulged Quentin's love for film and wrote an unmade film script. Tarantino confesses he mined it for *Django Unchained* (2012), for which he won the Oscar for best original screenplay.

Above all, while Tarantino knows his directors and actors, producers and studios, screenplays are what he values most. It's a book by a man who lives, eats and breathes film, and I loved every page, though a few photos would've been nice (the cover's photo is McQueen with Sam Peckinpah on the sets of *The Getaway*). Hopefully, Anurag Kashyap will one day write something similar. ■

Aditya Sinha